

“I DO NOT CARE WHETHER I LIVE OR DIE…I HAVE LIVED A LONG LIFE AND I AM PROUD THAT I SPENT THE WHOLE OF MY LIFE IN THE SERVICE OF MY PEOPLE.”

The centre of politics

Indira Gandhi, India’s only female prime minister, was the daughter of Jawaharlal and Kamala Nehru. After a childhood at the centre of politics, Indira joined the Congress at twenty-one. She was chosen to succeed Lal Bahadur Shastri as the leader of the party in 1966, when the latter died unexpectedly. The Congress Syndicate (a small, powerful group within the party) had chosen Indira as they believed she was inexperienced and could be easily controlled. She proved them all wrong by swiftly seizing power and splitting the party in two. In 1971, she further strengthened her position by leading her party to a large electoral victory.